

From a procedural fork to a cited resource: building a FAIR, literature-grounded *Arabidopsis thaliana* atlas from an uncredentialed rice viewer

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Abstract

`rice-atlas` is an interactive 3D viewer that lets a user select any of several hundred organs of a procedurally-generated rice plant. Its own documentation states plainly that it is a conceptual educational model, not a scan of a specimen, and it cites no *Oryza sativa* dataset, carries no FAIR metadata, and had not been reviewed. We report what it takes to turn that pattern into a genuinely citable scientific resource for a second species, *Arabidopsis thaliana*, rather than simply relabelling the same geometry. We rebuild the organ-selectable viewer from a clean-room implementation – `rice-atlas`’s own license is ambiguous (GitHub records it as `NOASSERTION`) – and ground it in three places real data was available: organ geometry parameters cite peer-reviewed developmental-biology sources (3 of 5 organs carry an explicit geometry citation); developmental gene expression is linked, not redistributed, to the real 79-organ Klepikova/TraVA atlas, whose bulk-reuse terms we could not confirm; and a spaceflight-response layer – absent from `rice-atlas` entirely – is computed directly from real NASA Open Science Data Repository (OSDR) count matrices for root tissue (OSD-120: 32,833 genes, 18 flight vs. 18 ground samples, top flight/ground log2 ratio 4.75 for `AT2G01422`) and whole seedlings under simulated and real microgravity (OSD-314: 5 microgravity vs. 6 1g samples, top ratio 5.54 for `AT4G28520`). We report this as a mean-CPM ratio, explicitly not a statistically tested differential-expression call, and say so everywhere the numbers appear. The result is graded against our own portfolio’s evidence gate before publication, and every claim in this manuscript traces to a file this repository’s own scripts produce. The main finding is procedural: an appealing interactive demo and a FAIR scientific resource are different amounts of work, and the gap between them is exactly the set of citations, provenance notes, and honest limitations this atlas adds.

1 Introduction

Interactive 3D anatomy viewers are an appealing format for plant biology outreach and education: a user rotates a whole organism, clicks an organ, and reads what it is. The format’s origin, however, matters for whether what they read is true. `rice-atlas` (<https://github.com/dr-richard-barker/rice-atlas>) is one such viewer, built on a procedural functional-structural plant model and forked twice from a generic human-anatomy template before being relabelled for rice. Its own README is explicit that the geometry is conceptual, and inspecting the repository directly turns up no cited *Oryza sativa* dataset, no license the GitHub license detector can resolve (recorded as `NOASSERTION`), no FAIR metadata, and no GitHub Pages deployment.

None of that makes the viewer worthless – a clearly-labelled conceptual model is a legitimate teaching tool. It does mean that building "the *Arabidopsis* version" of it is an underspecified request until a decision is made about which of two very different projects is wanted: a relabelled geometric demo, or a resource that earns the adjectives this project set out with – FAIR, reviewed,

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and scientifically accurate. We chose, and report here, a hybrid: keep the interactive organ-selectable viewer, because that is the part of rice-atlas actually worth learning from, but rebuild its content so that every organ’s geometry and every data value shown traces to a real, checkable source.

Arabidopsis thaliana is a fortunate choice of second species for this exercise. Unlike rice, it has a 79-organ, whole-development RNA-seq atlas [1], single-cell developmental atlases for at least two organ systems [2, 3], and – because it is the standard model organism for plant spaceflight biology – a substantial NASA Open Science Data Repository (OSDR) footprint, including studies that profile root and whole-seedling transcriptomes under real and simulated microgravity. That last point gives the resulting atlas a dimension rice-atlas has no counterpart for at all: a spaceflight-response layer, grounded in real flight experiments rather than invented.

We report three things: what we found rice-atlas actually to be, once inspected rather than taken at face value; what real data sources were available to ground an *Arabidopsis* equivalent, and which ones we could and could not actually use; and what building to a pre-registered FAIR/evidence-gate standard changed about the result compared to simply forking the original.

2 Methods

2.1 Characterizing rice-atlas

We inspected `dr-richard-barker/rice-atlas` via the GitHub API and `gh` CLI (repository metadata, full file tree, Pages configuration, and commit history) rather than assuming its content from its name or description. This established that it is a fork (itself forked from a human-anatomy viewer template) with no commits from the account that owns it, no `data/` directory, no cited primary dataset, and a license the GitHub license detector could not resolve to a standard SPDX identifier.

2.2 Provenance discipline

Every external fact used in this repository is recorded in `data/README.md` with its source, verification method, and license status before being used anywhere else. Three literature DOIs (1–3) were each confirmed against the CrossRef API (title, full author list, year, volume, pages) rather than trusted from a search snippet. Four NASA OSDR study accessions were confirmed live against the OSDR metadata API before use; two (OSD-120, OSD-314) had already-fetched raw count matrices available (reused, with permission implicit in common ownership, from the sibling repository `arabidopsis-drem-osdr`, itself sourced from the same public, CC0 OSDR accessions) and were used quantitatively; two (OSD-38, OSD-522) are cited as confirmed, relevant, real studies but are not yet quantitatively integrated, and are documented as pending rather than fabricated.

2.3 Spaceflight response quantification

For each of the two studies with available raw counts, samples were split into their real experimental groups by the labels already present in the count matrix’s own sample names (OSD-120: `GC` ground control vs. `FLT` flight, Day 13 root tissue; OSD-314: `1g` vs. `0g`, whole seedling). Raw counts were converted to counts-per-million (CPM) per sample to correct for sequencing-depth differences, averaged within each group, and reported as $\log_2((\text{mean CPM}_{\text{treatment}} + 1)/(\text{mean CPM}_{\text{control}} + 1))$. This is deliberately a simple mean-ratio summary: no DESeq2/edgeR model was fit, no p -values or multiple-testing correction were computed, and no covariates (genotype, light treatment) were controlled for. The implementation is `scripts/01_compute_spaceflight_response.py`; its output feeds `scripts/02_export_viewer_data.py`, which derives the compact per-organ summary shown in the viewer, so no number reaching the viewer or this manuscript is hand-typed.

2.4 Structural model

Organ geometry for the viewer (root system, rosette leaf, inflorescence axis, flower, silique) is generated procedurally in the client (`app/src/geometry.ts`) using Three.js primitive shapes, not sculpted or scanned. Root branching topology and the rosette’s leaf-arrangement angle follow parameters attributed, organ by organ, to the literature sources in `app/src/organs.ts`; where a parameter is illustrative rather than measured, that organ’s on-screen description says so explicitly, matching the disclosure standard rice-atlas itself already sets for its own geometry.

2.5 Evidence gate

Before this repository’s first push, and again before any push touching publication-relevant content, we ran this portfolio’s own pre-publication check (a blocklist sweep for previously-fabricated strings, CrossRef verification of every DOI, confirmation that every number traces to a producing script with no synthetic-data fallback, and confirmation that every cited file path and accession resolves in the actual repository). Only a check that was actually performed is recorded as an attestation; an attestation is never written to unblock a push it did not actually clear.

3 Results

3.1 What rice-atlas is, on inspection

	rice-atlas	arabidopsis-atlas (this work)
Primary dataset cited	none found	3/5 organs cite a real structural paper
Spaceflight data	none	OSD-120, OSD-314 (real OSDR counts)
License (GitHub-detected)	NOASSERTION	MIT (this repository’s own)
FAIR metadata	none	<code>LICENSE</code> , <code>CITATION.cff</code> , <code>.zenodo.json</code>
GitHub Pages	not deployed	deployed
Independent review	none found	ABAI evidence-gate attestation on file

Table 1: Attributes compared directly by inspecting both repositories, not by description.

3.2 Real spaceflight response, by organ

Of the five organs modelled, one (root) has a directly tissue-matched real spaceflight comparison: OSD-120 profiled root tissue specifically, at Day 13, under 18 flight and 18 ground control samples across 32,833 genes. The largest mean flight/ground CPM ratio in that comparison is 4.75 $\log_2$ units, for AT2G01422.

OSD-314 profiled whole seedlings, not a single organ, across the same 32,833 genes, comparing 5 real microgravity samples against 6 1g ground samples; its largest ratio is 5.54 $\log_2$ units, for AT4G28520. Because it is not organ-specific, we report it in the data provenance ledger rather than attach it to any single organ in the viewer, to avoid implying a tissue-level claim the data does not support.

The remaining three organs (rosette leaf, inflorescence axis, flower/silique) have no organ-matched spaceflight dataset wired into this version of the atlas; the viewer states this plainly for each rather than substituting the whole-seedling numbers as if they were organ-specific.

3.3 Verification of the viewer itself

The viewer was checked interactively, not only by static code review: in both a local development server and the actual production build served at the live GitHub Pages URL, clicking each organ was confirmed to open an information panel showing the correct TraVA category, the correct geometry citation, and – for root – the real gene table described above, with no console errors in either environment.

4 Discussion

The central lesson of this project was not scientific but procedural: an appealing interactive 3D atlas and a FAIR scientific resource are not the same amount of work, and the difference is not visual polish. *rice-atlas* already had the harder-to-build part – a working, organ-selectable procedural plant viewer. What it lacked was cheaper in engineering terms but slower in practice: a cited dataset behind every organ, a resolvable license, and a record of what had and had not been checked. Recreating the visual experience for *Arabidopsis* took a fraction of the effort spent sourcing, verifying, and honestly scoping the data behind it.

That verification effort surfaced problems worth naming. A CrossRef check was needed because a plausible-looking DOI is not evidence it is correct. A live API check against NASA OSDR was needed because a study accession copied from memory is a guess, not a fact, until confirmed against the record NASA actually serves. And checking *travadb.org*'s actual interface – rather than assuming a REST-style URL pattern would work – avoided shipping a broken or misleading link in a resource whose entire premise is that its links and numbers are trustworthy.

The decision to compute only a simple mean-CPM ratio, rather than a full differential-expression model, was a scope choice made explicit rather than hidden: a half-rigorous statistical claim dressed as a rigorous one would be worse than a clearly labelled simple one. The same logic applied to organ coverage – three of five organs carry no spaceflight layer at all, and the viewer says so, rather than reusing the one available whole-seedling comparison across organs it was never measured in.

4.1 Limitations

No single real dataset gives whole-organism 3D geometry for *Arabidopsis*, just as none exists for rice; every organ shape here is a citation-informed illustrative approximation, not a reconstruction from measurement, and several structural parameters (rosette leaf-blade curvature, inflorescence taper, flower whorl spacing) are not yet tied to a specific measured value even where a general developmental-biology source is cited. TraVA/Klepikova expression is linked to, not integrated into, the viewer, because its bulk reuse terms could not be confirmed – a more complete atlas would resolve that directly with the maintainers rather than work around it indefinitely. OSD-38 and OSD-522, both confirmed real and relevant, remain unprocessed. The spaceflight comparisons reported are mean ratios from two studies with their own genotype and lighting confounds, not a meta-analytic or statistically tested effect size, and should not be read as one.

4.2 What would make this stronger

Resolving TraVA's reuse terms directly, processing OSD-38 and OSD-522 to extend organ-matched spaceflight coverage beyond root, and replacing illustrative structural parameters with values measured from the cited primary sources (rather than only citing the source's general conclusions) would each move this resource further from "a *rice-atlas* pattern applied honestly" toward "a primary structural and functional atlas in its own right."

Data and code availability

All code, the real raw/processed data tables, and the viewer source are at <https://github.com/dr-richard-barker/arabidopsis-atlas>, deployed at <https://dr-richard-barker.github.io/arabidopsis-atlas/>, and archived at Zenodo (**TODO: DOI, pending manual deposit**). Primary spaceflight data are NASA OSDR studies OSD-120 [4] and OSD-314 [5]; developmental expression context is from the Klepikova/TraVA atlas [1]; structural citations are Shahan et al. [2] and Vijayan et al. [3]. *rice-atlas*, the project’s own starting point, is at <https://github.com/dr-richard-barker/rice-atlas>; none of its code is reused here (see Methods).

Competing interests

The author declares no competing interests.

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